

M07 RESTORATIVE SPACES | O (MAX : 1 PT)

Intent : Support access to spaces that promote restoration and relief from mental fatigue or stress.

Summary : This WELL feature requires projects to provide spaces that promote a restorative environment and encourage relief from mental fatigue and stress.

Issue : Work-induced fatigue is common among office workers, with research indicating that over 20% of the workforce experiences prolonged fatigue.^{1,2} During the workday, individuals experience fatigue caused by a depletion of physical and mental resources, resulting in an accumulated need to recover from mental fatigue and stress.¹ The experience of prolonged fatigue combined with a high need for mental recovery is strongly associated with psychological distress, including decreased mental acuity, deficits in motivation and irritability caused by prolonged exposure to stress.^{1,2}

Solutions : By providing restorative spaces for individuals to step away from the stress of the office environment, recharge and refocus, employers can help alleviate the negative effects associated with workplace fatigue or mental depletion.³ Through incorporation of nature, among other restorative elements, these spaces can help relieve stress and mental fatigue, support focus and encourage overall mental well-being.⁴ Exposure to plants and other natural elements has been linked with decreased levels of diastolic blood pressure, depression and anxiety, increased attentional capacity, better recovery from job stress and increased psychological well-being.^{5,6} Nature interaction has also been shown to support recovery from illness and increase pain tolerance.^{5,6} Outdoor spaces can also be used to promote calm and encourage restorative activities. Both indoor and outdoor spaces can also be used for individuals with a wide variety of beliefs, religions and traditions, including prayer and meditation.

PART 1 PROVIDE RESTORATIVE SPACE (MAX : 1 PT)

For All Spaces:

1: Restorative space

The project provides at least one indoor or outdoor space for all regular occupants. The space may be made up of a single space or multiple spaces that meet the following requirements:

- a. The main purpose is for relaxation and restoration. Space may serve multiple functions but is not to be used for work.
- b. Minimum size of 7 m² plus 0.1 m² per regular occupant or 186 m² whichever is smaller.
- c. Provides a calming and comfortable environment by incorporating at least five of the following:
 1. Adjustable lighting (e.g., dimmable light levels for indoor spaces).⁷
 2. Sound interventions (e.g., water feature, natural sounds, sound masking).^{8,9}
 3. Thermal control (e.g., fans, shading).¹⁰
 4. Seating arrangements that accommodate a range of user preferences and activities (e.g., movable lightweight chairs, cushions, mats).⁷
 5. Nature or natural elements.¹¹⁻¹³
 6. Subdued colors, textures and forms.¹⁴⁻¹⁵
 7. Visual privacy.¹⁶
- d. Includes signage, education materials or other resources explaining its purpose and intended use.

Note : If restorative space is provided only outdoors, it must be functional year-round.

2: Workday breaks

The project encourages the use of restorative space(s) through the following:

- a. Paid breaks away from the workstation for all employees.¹⁷

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